



MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

WHY DID MEDIEVAL MEDICINE CHANGE SO LITTLE — AND WHAT FINALLY BROKE THE DEADLOCK?

*Paper 1: Medicine Through Time with the Western
Front - Medieval*

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

Edexcel Specification: c1250–c1500

- **1. Causes of disease:** Supernatural/religious explanations, Astrology, Four Humours, and Miasma.
- **2. Prevention and treatment:** Religious actions, bloodletting, purging, purifying air.
- **3. Medical care:** The role of physicians, apothecaries, barber surgeons, and hospitals.
- **4. Case Study: The Black Death (1348):** Beliefs about its causes, treatments, and prevention.

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?			
L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?			
L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how supernatural and religious factors influenced beliefs about the cause of illness.
- ☐ Analyse the rational, natural theories of disease used in medieval England.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What does the term 'public health' refer to?

Name one ancient civilization that heavily influenced medieval medicine.

Which Greek physician originally created the Theory of the Four Humours?

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

What are the four humours?

What was 'miasma'?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

Why did the medieval Church promote the ideas of Galen?

Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

What was the 'urine chart' used for in medieval diagnosis?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Miasma Four Humours Theory of Opposites
--

In medieval England, medical beliefs were heavily dominated by ancient theories rather than scientific observation. Under the popular [.] theory, a patient's temperature or cold was diagnosed as a bodily imbalance. To treat a cold, a physician might use Galen's [.] to recommend eating hot and dry spices. However, when entire towns fell ill, people often blamed [.], believing that foul-smelling air from rotting waste in the streets was poisoning their lungs.

Q1. Identify one reason why the Church promoted Galen's ideas.

Q2. Describe the Theory of the Four Humours.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why did the Church promote the work of the ancient Roman doctor Galen?

- ☐ A. Because Galen proved that God sent diseases as a punishment.
- ☐ B. Because Galen's theory of a perfectly designed body fit Christian creation theology.
- ☐ C. Because Galen was a devout Christian.
- ☐ D. Because he was the personal physician to the Pope.

Q4. Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

Q5. Evaluate the significance of the Church in holding back medical progress in the Middle Ages.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Which factor was the most powerful barrier to medieval medical progress: the absolute authority of the Christian Church, or the logical appeal of the Theory of the Four Humours?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Church control of universities/libraries, or how symptoms like sneezing phlegm seemed to prove the humours existed).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Medieval Church's Impact on Medicine

For decades, traditional historians portrayed the medieval Catholic Church as a dogmatic institution that actively and deliberately stifled medical progress by banning dissections and imprisoning independent researchers like Roger Bacon. However, modern revisionist historians argue that the Church was not deliberately preventing progress. They point out that without the Church's libraries, the vital ancient medical texts of Hippocrates and Galen would have been lost entirely. Furthermore, they argue that the level of medieval technology meant that microbes could not be observed anyway, meaning that treatment would remain ineffective regardless of religious dominance, and that the Church was the only institution actively offering organised care to the sick through monastic hospitals.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. 'The Theory of the Four Humours was the main idea about the cause of disease in the Middle Ages'. How far do you agree? Explain your answer. You may use the following in your answer:

- Galen
- the Church

You must also use information of your own.

[16 marks • 20 mins]

[illegible]

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Describe two features of the Theory of the Four Humours. (4 marks)

[4 marks • 5 mins]

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q9. Explain why there was so little change in ideas about the cause of disease in the years c.1250-c.1500.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Church
- Galen

You must also use information of your own.

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Pupil Voice

How did the events of today's lesson make you feel, and why?

General Notes

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L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the connection between medieval beliefs about disease and their approaches to treatment and prevention.
- ☐ Evaluate the roles, training, and accessibility of different medical healers in medieval society.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

What was 'miasma'?

What are the four humours?

Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

What was the 'urine chart' used for in medieval diagnosis?

What does the term 'public health' refer to?

Name one ancient civilization that heavily influenced medieval medicine.

Under the Theory of Opposites, how would a fever (hot/dry) be treated?

Which Greek physician originally created the Theory of the Four Humours?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Phlebotomy Regimen Sanitatis Theriaca
--

Your Sentence:

Q1. Identify one supernatural method used to prevent disease.

Q2. Describe the process of bloodletting.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What was the main difference between an apothecary and a physician?

- ☐ A. Physicians performed surgery, apothecaries diagnosed illness.
- ☐ B. Apothecaries mixed herbal remedies based on experience, while physicians diagnosed using astrology and ancient books.
- ☐ C. Apothecaries were trained at university, physicians were not.
- ☐ D. Physicians were always monks, apothecaries were always women.

Q4. Explain how the Theory of Opposites was used in treatments.

Q5. To what extent were medieval treatments dangerous for patients?

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: If you were a medieval peasant, who would you trust more to care for your family: an expensive university-trained physician who diagnosed using urine and star charts, or a female family member treating you in the home with herbal remedies?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the Paston family letters showing deep distrust of professional physicians, or the fact that women treated families for free with garden herbs like marigolds and clover).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Effectiveness of Medieval Hospitals

Traditional historical accounts often dismissed medieval hospitals as dirty, unhygienic places of death where patients shared beds and received no real medicine. However, modern revisionist historians point out that judged by medieval standards, monastic hospitals actually maintained high standards of cleanliness, as bed linens and clothing were regularly washed by nuns. While they did not perform surgery and excluded infectious patients to prevent the spread of disease, they provided crucial spiritual care, warmth, and nutritious food. For patients not suffering from terminal illnesses, monastic care focusing on 'care, not cure' was highly successful in allowing the body to rest and recover in a comfortable, sanitary environment.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. 'In the years c1250-c1500, the physician was the most important person providing care and treatment.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Explain why bleeding and purging were such common treatments in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

[illegible]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q9. Explain why there was little change in the care provided by hospitals in the period c.1250-c.1500.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Monks and nuns
- infectious diseases

You must also use information of your own.

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Pupil Voice

Which part of today's lesson did you find the most difficult or confusing, and what did you do to overcome it?

General Notes

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L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the religious and supernatural responses to the Black Death.
- ☐ Analyse the rational and governmental methods used to prevent and treat the plague.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What was the purpose of 'bleeding' (phlebotomy) in medieval medicine?

What was the role of a medieval apothecary?

How did medieval hospitals differ from modern ones?

What was 'purging'?

What was the role of a medieval barber surgeon?

What was the 'Regimen Sanitatis'?

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

What was 'miasma'?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

What are the four humours?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Buboes**

Q1. Identify the true cause of the Black Death.

Q2. Describe two ways people tried to prevent the Black Death.

Q3. Explain why the government's response to the Black Death failed.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

Why were the government's orders to clean the streets completely ineffective at stopping the Black Death?

- ☐ A. Because the peasants refused to obey the King's laws.
- ☐ B. Because the disease was actually a punishment from God.
- ☐ C. Because they were trying to remove bad smells (miasma), but ignored the rats and fleas that actually spread the disease.
- ☐ D. Because the dirt on the streets was actually killing the germs.

Q5. Evaluate the impact of the Black Death on medieval society.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Was the medieval response to the Black Death dominated more by desperate spiritual panic or by logical, rational attempts at disease prevention based on the scientific ideas of the time?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence (e.g., the public whipping of the flagellants vs. mayors ordering rakers to clear dung and waste from the streets to stop bad air).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Socio-Economic Impact of the Black Death

Historians are deeply divided over the long-term impact of the Black Death on medieval English society. Traditional historians, such as G.M. Trevelyan, argued that the demographic catastrophe was a massive watershed of progress-the crucial turning point that caused severe labor shortages, ended feudalism, and paved the way for the Renaissance and Industrial Revolution. Conversely, modern revisionist historians argue that the Black Death did not suddenly destroy the feudal system overnight. Instead, they suggest it merely accelerated economic trends that were already underway, pointing to the immediate return of the plague every 10 to 20 years which caused prolonged economic depression and stagnation, rather than rapid modernizing progress.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. 'The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. You may use the following in your answer:

- bloodletting
- dissection

You must also use information of your own.

[16 marks • 20 mins]

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TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q8. Explain why the Black Death spread so rapidly in Britain in 1348.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

[illegible]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q9. 'The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period (c1250-c1500) was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Four Humours
- The Black Death

You must also use information of your own.

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Pupil Voice

If you were teaching this lesson to Year 6, what is the ONE most important thing you would make sure they remembered?

General Notes

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End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 1: Medicine Through Time

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

Factors Overview: Medieval

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	

